Planting Something Slow

Civic Skill: Long-Term Thinking | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 4 (Learning) & Outcome 2 (Community) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will experience the relationship between present action and future outcome by planting a seed and caring for it over multiple weeks, building tolerance for delayed results.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can plant something and care for it even before I can see anything growing.
- I can predict what might happen next.
- I can connect what I do now with what will happen later.

MATERIALS

- Seeds (fast-growing varieties: bean seeds, sunflowers, radishes)
- Small pots or clear plastic cups (so roots are visible)
- Potting mix
- A class timeline on the wall — at least 8 weeks long, with weekly markers
- Measurement sticks and a shared observation journal
- Camera for weekly documentation

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. INTRODUCTION (5 min): Hold up a seed. 'Right now, this looks like nothing much. But inside it, everything it will ever be is already there — it just needs time, water, and care. We're going to give it all three. But we won't see anything for a while. Can we wait?'

2. PLANTING (10 min): Each child (or pair) plants their seed. As they work: 'What do you think is happening inside the seed right now, even though we can't see it?' Introduce the word 'invisible change.'

3. PREDICTION ACTIVITY (5 min): Children draw what they think their plant will look like in two weeks, then in six weeks. Seal the drawings — open them later when plants are growing.

4. TIMELINE INTRODUCTION (3 min): Mark today on the class timeline. 'Each week we'll come back and add to this. We're telling the story of something that grows slowly — and we're the people who made it possible.'

5. ONGOING RITUAL (weekly, 5 min): Return to the plants. Measure, observe, photograph, add to the timeline. 'Remember when we planted? Remember what we predicted? What's the same? What surprised us?'

EXTENSIONS

- Letter to future self: dictate a message to open when the plant is fully grown
- Connect to food: what did someone have to do — and wait for — before we could eat this?
- Care roster: assign weekly plant care responsibilities. What happens to the plant if no one does their part?

ASSESSMENT

- Observe: Does the child check on the plant between formal observation sessions? Intrinsic care is a strong indicator
- Documentation: the class timeline is a portfolio artefact — annotate with children's language
- Key question at week 4: 'Was it hard to wait? What made you keep caring for it?'

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- How did children's patience with the plant shift over the weeks?
- Were there moments of discouragement? How did you hold those without rescuing children from them?
- What did caring for something slowly teach children that faster activities cannot?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 4 (Learning) & Outcome 2 (Community). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.